



Lost Dogs Ayrshire

WATER

Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)

Date issued	10/07/26
Written by	Darren Hunt
Version	1.0
Review date	10/07/28



1. Purpose

The purpose of this Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) is to provide clear guidance and establish a safe, consistent approach for Lost Dogs Ayrshire volunteers responding to reports of missing or loose dogs in or near water environments.

Water environments, including rivers, burns, lochs, reservoirs, canals, ponds, and coastal areas, present significant and often unpredictable hazards. These may include deep or fast-flowing water, unstable banks, hidden obstacles, steep embankments, cold-water shock, changing weather conditions, and the potential for serious injury or fatality. As a result, incidents involving or adjacent to water must be treated as high-risk situations requiring a safety-led response.

2. Safety First Principle

Water-related incidents are dynamic, and environmental conditions can change rapidly. What may initially appear to be a low-risk situation can quickly become life-threatening.

Volunteer safety always takes absolute priority over the rescue of a dog.

Volunteers must never:

- Enter water where there is a foreseeable risk to their personal safety.
- Enter deep, fast-flowing, or flood water.
- Enter lochs, reservoirs, canals, rivers with strong currents, or coastal waters to recover a dog.
- Enter water where the depth, current, or underwater hazards cannot be safely assessed.
- Attempt a rescue that exceeds their training, experience, or physical capability.

Volunteers should only operate from a safe location and continually assess the changing conditions.

Where a dog is located within a shallow burn, drainage ditch, or other low-risk watercourse with little or no flowing water, volunteers may consider entering the area only where all of the following apply:

- The water is shallow and slow moving.
- The bed of the watercourse is clearly visible and free from significant hazards.
- Secure footing can be maintained throughout.
- A safe entry and exit route is available.
- The volunteer can withdraw immediately if conditions change.
- The action can be carried out without placing themselves or others at risk.

If any of these conditions cannot be met, volunteers must not enter the water and should request assistance from the appropriate emergency service.

Where there is any doubt regarding the level of risk, volunteers must not enter the water and should request assistance from the appropriate emergency service.

2.1 Managing Public Interaction and External Pressure

When attending incidents involving members of the public, volunteers should be aware that water-related incidents can generate heightened emotions, urgency, and unintentional pressure to act immediately.

Members of the public may look to Lost Dogs Ayrshire volunteers to enter the water or attempt a rescue. Volunteers must remain professional, explain the need for a safe and controlled response,

and must not allow external pressure to influence their decision-making.

During any high-stress rescue situation:

- Volunteers must not take unnecessary risks to satisfy requests from members of the public.
- Volunteers have the authority to pause, withdraw, or request additional support if they believe the situation is unsafe.
- Where a water rescue is beyond the capability of volunteers, the appropriate emergency services should be contacted immediately.
- A safe and controlled response is always preferable to a rushed response that creates additional risk.

3. Initial Scene Assessment

Upon receiving a report or arriving at the location, volunteers should establish:

- The exact location of the dog.
- The type of water environment involved (e.g. loch, river, burn, canal, reservoir, pond, or coastal area).
- Whether the dog is in the water, on the bank, trapped, or moving near the water's edge.
- The condition of the water, including depth, flow, current, weather conditions, and any visible hazards.
- Whether any member of the public has entered, or is attempting to enter, the water in an effort to recover the dog.
- The dog's behaviour and direction of travel.
- Any immediate hazards to volunteers, members of the public, or the dog.
- Suitable access and exit routes for volunteers and emergency services, where appropriate.

No action should be taken until the situation has been assessed and it is safe to proceed.

4. Dynamic Risk Assessment

A dynamic risk assessment must be carried out before any action is taken and continually reviewed throughout the incident.

The assessment should consider:

- The type of water environment involved (e.g. loch, river, burn, canal, reservoir, pond, or coastal area).
- Whether the dog is in the water, trapped, or at risk of entering the water.
- The depth, flow, current, and temperature of the water.
- Weather conditions, visibility, and time of day.
- The stability of banks, embankments, shorelines, and surrounding terrain.
- Access and exit routes for volunteers and emergency services.
- The dog's behaviour and movement patterns.
- The presence of members of the public and the likelihood of them attempting a rescue.
- Risks to volunteers, members of the public, and the dog.

Water conditions can change rapidly due to weather, water flow, tides, or other environmental factors. Volunteers should be aware that conditions further upstream, away from the immediate incident location, may also affect the water environment and can quickly change the level of risk at the scene.

Volunteers must continually reassess the situation and adjust their response accordingly.

If there is any doubt regarding safety, volunteers must withdraw to a place of safety and report the matter to the appropriate emergency service.

5. Escalation and Emergency Service Notification

Where a dog is reported to be in, trapped by, or at immediate risk from water, Lost Dogs Ayrshire will encourage the reporting person to contact 999 without delay and request the appropriate emergency service.

Depending on the location, this may include:

- Fire and Rescue Service for inland water incidents, including rivers, burns, lochs, canals, reservoirs, and ponds.
- HM Coastguard for coastal incidents, including beaches, cliffs, harbours, estuaries, and shoreline locations.
- Where appropriate, HM Coastguard may deploy RNLI lifeboats or other specialist water rescue resources.

Where emergency services have been requested, volunteers should support the response by providing accurate location information, updates on the dog's movements, and any significant changes in circumstances. Volunteers must not undertake actions that place themselves or others at unnecessary risk while awaiting the arrival of emergency services.

6. Immediate Actions and Scene Management

Where a dog is confirmed or suspected to be within a water environment, volunteers should:

- Maintain a safe distance at all times.
- Observe and record the dog's location and movements where safe to do so.
- Avoid any actions that may encourage the dog further into the water or towards deeper or more hazardous areas.

- Withdraw if conditions become unsafe.
- Relay information to coordination teams and emergency services as appropriate.

Volunteers must not attempt to rescue a dog whilst it remains in water.

It is important to establish at the earliest opportunity whether the dog's owner is present at the scene.

Where the owner is present, volunteers should encourage them to remain clear of the water and explain that entering the water may place them at significant risk. If there is concern that the owner intends to enter the water, volunteers should encourage them to remain in a place of safety and contact the appropriate emergency services where necessary.

Volunteers must not place themselves at risk in an attempt to prevent the owner from entering the water.

Where it is known or believed that the dog's owner was present prior to the arrival of volunteers but cannot be located, volunteers should consider the possibility that the owner may have entered the water in an attempt to rescue their dog.

This must be treated as a potential life-threatening emergency. Volunteers should contact the appropriate emergency services and provide any available information regarding the owner's last known location, the time they were last seen, and any witness accounts.

Volunteers must not enter the water to search for the owner and should continue to gather and relay relevant information from a place of safety while awaiting emergency service attendance.

7. Operational Intelligence and Information Sharing

Information gathered through visual observations, reports from the owner, members of the public, or other sources must be treated as supporting intelligence only.

All tactical decisions must:

- Prioritise volunteer and public safety.
- Be made from a safe location away from water hazards where possible.
- Be consistent with instructions provided by the appropriate emergency services where engaged.

Observations and relevant information may be shared with emergency services to support a coordinated response and safe resolution planning.

Where emergency services attend the incident, volunteers should make themselves known to the attending personnel where it is safe and appropriate to do so. Volunteers should provide a clear and concise brief, including:

- The dog's last known location and movements.
- Details of the owner or any concerns regarding their safety.
- Any other relevant information that may assist the response.

Lost Dogs Ayrshire volunteers may offer assistance and information to emergency services where required; however, volunteers must follow instructions provided by emergency responders and must not undertake actions outside their safety limitations.

Where emergency services have been requested but have not yet attended, volunteers should provide updates through the appropriate communication channels. If there is a significant change in circumstances, increased risk, change in location, or

new information that may affect the response, volunteers should contact 999 to provide an update.

8. Understanding Water Behaviour and Hazards

Water environments are dynamic and can behave differently depending on flow, depth, weather conditions, obstacles, and surrounding terrain. Volunteers should have a basic understanding of how water movement can affect the location and behaviour of a dog.

8.1 River Flow, Eddies and Dog Movement

In rivers and flowing water, areas of slower-moving water known as eddies can form. These are areas where water circulates back on itself, often occurring near riverbanks, bends, rocks, structures, or other obstructions.

A dog that has entered or been carried downstream may instinctively attempt to reach the riverbank. Where successful, the dog may exit the main flow of the river in an area of slower-moving water, such as an eddy.

However, dogs within flowing water can become exhausted quickly, and their movement may be unpredictable. A dog that disappears from sight should not automatically be assumed to have continued downstream or entered deeper water. It may have reached the riverbank, moved into slower-moving water, become hidden by vegetation or terrain, or become trapped by an obstruction.

Volunteers should not enter the water to assist unless the risks have been assessed as low and it can be done safely in accordance with this SOP.

8.2 Weirs and Recirculating Water Hazards

Weirs are among the most hazardous features found within rivers. The water flow over and beneath a weir can create powerful recirculating currents, known as a hydraulic roller, which can create a dangerous towback effect. This can repeatedly pull objects, animals, and people back towards the face of the weir and prevent them from escaping the flow.

If a dog has been observed entering a river and reaching a weir, but is not seen continuing downstream or emerging afterwards, there is a possibility that the dog may have become trapped within the recirculating water below or around the weir.

It may be possible for a dog or other object to briefly resurface within the flow; however, the returning current can draw it back into the hydraulic roller and prevent it from escaping the area.

Dogs and other objects can remain trapped within these currents for extended periods before being released naturally or moving to another location.

Where a dog is suspected to be involved with a weir or other significant water hazard, volunteers should not attempt rescue and should immediately contact the appropriate emergency services, providing the location, observations, and any relevant information available.

8.3 Human Behaviour and Water Rescue Risks

During water-related incidents, owners and members of the public may place themselves at significant risk while attempting to rescue a dog.

The strong emotional connection between a person and their dog can lead to instinctive decisions, including entering the water without fully considering the dangers involved.

Where a person enters the water to attempt a rescue, the incident may quickly change from an animal rescue situation to a potential human life rescue situation.

Volunteers should be aware that entering cold or moving water presents significant risks, including cold water shock, reduced swimming ability, rapid exhaustion, and the potential for a person to become overwhelmed or unable to return to safety.

If a person enters the water and does not immediately return to a place of safety, volunteers should treat this as a potential life-threatening emergency and contact the appropriate emergency services.

Volunteers must not enter the water to attempt a rescue and should continue to provide information and support from a place of safety while awaiting emergency service attendance.

9. Lone Working

Volunteers attending incidents involving water environments should avoid lone working wherever reasonably practicable.

However, as Lost Dogs Ayrshire cannot guarantee that two or more volunteers will be available at all times, lone working may occasionally be unavoidable.

Where lone working cannot be avoided, volunteers should:

- Inform another team member of their location and intended actions.
- Ensure they have a clear route away from the area if required.
- Maintain regular communication through the organisation's approved communication channels.
- Provide updates at appropriate intervals.
- Avoid isolated locations where personal safety may be compromised.

- Remain aware of changing water conditions, weather, and environmental hazards.
- Avoid positioning themselves in areas where access, retreat, or communication may become difficult.
- Withdraw immediately if they feel unsafe or if circumstances change.
- Notify the appropriate team member when leaving the incident location and confirm when they have safely returned home, returned to work, or resumed their previous activity.

If communication cannot be maintained, or the volunteer believes the situation has become unsafe, they should withdraw and reassess whether it is safe to continue.

10. Use of Drones

Consideration may be given to the use of drones to assist with situational awareness during water-related incidents, including rivers, lochs, reservoirs, coastal areas, and other water environments where the dog is in an area that is difficult to access safely or where aerial observation may assist in maintaining visual contact without placing volunteers at risk.

The use of drones is for observation and tracking purposes only.

Under no circumstances should a drone be used to:

- Herd, chase, or deliberately influence the movement of a dog.
- Drive a dog away from, or towards, any location, including water hazards, shorelines, or volunteers.
- Fly in a manner that may cause distress to the dog or create an additional risk to public safety.
- Encourage or influence the movement of a dog into, along, or away from a water environment.

Any drone operations must comply with current UK Civil Aviation Authority (CAA) regulations, including CAP 722 and the UK Drone and Model Aircraft Code, and must only be undertaken by suitably competent operators in accordance with any applicable airspace restrictions.

Particular consideration must be given to airspace restrictions associated with emergency service activity, coastal locations, protected areas, and other restricted airspace.

The safety of the dog, volunteers, members of the public, emergency service personnel, and other airspace users must remain the primary consideration when deciding whether the use of a drone is appropriate.

11. Thermal Imaging and Optical Observation Equipment

Thermal cameras, thermal scopes, thermal binoculars, and other optical observation equipment may assist with situational awareness during water-related incidents.

Volunteers should understand that thermal imaging can be affected by water environments and may not always provide clear or accurate information.

Water can reflect, absorb, or distort thermal signatures, which may result in unreliable or misleading images. Thermal imaging should not be relied upon as the sole method of locating a dog within or around water.

A lack of visual confirmation should not be interpreted as confirmation that a dog is no longer present or that its location has been established.

Information obtained through thermal or optical equipment should be considered alongside other observations and environmental information when assessing the situation.